

Piano variation by Mozart

Mozart wrote 12 solo piano variations of a French folk song, "Ah! vous dirai-je, Maman" (K. 265, ca. 1781). Only variations 11 and 12 have tempo indications—Adagio and Allegro. Variation 8 is in a minor key, and variation 12 is in triple meter.

▽ "Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star"

You may know this theme as "Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star," "Baa Baa Black Sheep," or even "The Alphabet Song."

THEME

The musical score is written for piano in 2/4 time, marked *mf*. It consists of three systems of grand staves. The first system begins with a repeat sign. The melody is in the right hand, and the bass line is in the left hand. The second and third systems continue the piece, also ending with repeat signs.

REAL WORLD

Modern variations

Many modern composers have created theme and variations, sometimes using another composer's tune for inspiration. The mid-20th century tour de force for orchestra by Benjamin Britten, *Young Person's Guide to the Orchestra*, features 13 variations (and a grand closing fugue) on a theme by Henry Purcell (1659–95). Each variation features a different instrument section in the orchestra. Britten even wrote narration to precede each variation, introducing the instrument families and explaining how they make sound.



"Composing is like driving down a foggy road toward a **house**. Slowly you see details of the house, the color of the slates and bricks, the shape of the windows. The **notes are the bricks** and the **mortar** of the house." Benjamin Britten